

33
SOLDIERING ON

MAYBE BECAUSE I generally get along with soldiers, or maybe because I always wanted to be a soldier, I'm very partial to them. If I hadn't been a cricketer, I would have been a soldier. I know it. I just do.

Maybe the influence comes from friends. Many of my closest friends have been men in uniform. Or maybe it's because of the soldiers in my family. I love the army. I love their passion for Pakistan. Nobody loves Pakistan like soldiers do. They lay their lives down for Pakistan and don't talk about it. They are the first responders in an earthquake or a flood. Their lives are disciplined. They stay within their system. They don't cross boundaries, which is the way it should be. Well, at least most of the time.

Yes, there are bad apples in the army. There are soldiers who have misused their authority. I know I'm treading into controversial territory here but I must raise the question: why, every few years, is martial law imposed in Pakistan? What's the need for the army to step in every decade or so? Why here? Why not next door?

The answer lies within our democracy and with our democrats. Our votes don't matter. There is barely any delivery of services. There is hardly any accountability. The police, the tax authorities, the people in power: do they really do justice to their mandate? Are they well led by our democratic leaders? Sorry, but the answer is no.

That's where the army comes in. That's why they have to take over. I'm pretty sure that our armed forces – the current army, not the army of the 1980s or '90s – are professional enough to not interfere in the affairs of others if there is solid governance at the centre. Only once there is a vacuum created by the democrats does the military step in. It's natural. Even the great Inzamam-ul-Haq rumbled in to bowl a few overs in matches where the bowlers were not doing their job.

I'm very partial to the General Pervez Musharraf era. Yes, he took over Pakistan's leadership in a military coup. But in the first four to five years of his rule, Pakistan did magnificently well. Its economy boomed; its media was deregulated; trade liberalization improved. But ultimately, he